of demolitions and hosting many reconstructions. The historical trail—as progressively uncovered by a series of scholars like Diana Eck and Madhuri Desai, agreeing to disagree on many points—is not as bathed in resplendent Shiva light as the popular story.

"Like any other city, Kashi was always evolving, mutating... and moving in rhyme with the shifting course of the Ganga. The Banaras of today's exact location, the present landscape of ghats instilled in our minds by the Orientalist works of Company artists like the Daniells, is a relatively new being. It comes into prominence only in the 16th century, during Akbar's time," says filmmaker-writer Nilosree Biswas, author of *Banaras: Of Gods, Humans and Stories* (2021). Desai, whose magisterial *Banaras Reconstructed: Architecture and Sacred Space in a Hindu Holy City* (2017) was based on extensive research of material evidence and medieval textual sources, also speaks of "the complex relationship between regenerated sites of Hindu pilgrimage and Mughal urbanism...and cosmopolitanism". Other scholars talk of that century of 'Pax Mughalana' inaugurating an era of intellectual inquiry marked by astonishing vitality—and Kashi, with its esteem for Sanskrit scholarship, came to be a nodal point in a buzzing transnational network of knowledge. The Mughals as a genuinely creative force for the city, counterbalancing the destroyer trope. Akbar, certainly. Even Aurangzeb, before he razed the Vishweshwara temple, issued *firmans* to protect all temples of Kashi and its Brahmins, gave land grants to temples, and secured the Jangama Shaivite sect various rights. Call it paradox regained.

There's a lot we don't know. What we do know, says Biswas, is that the older Kashi was "further upriver, beyond the Malviya bridge"—now a large ASI-protected area. On whose shoulders did history pivot, then? "The key figure in the story is Narayana Bhatta, a Maharashtrian Brahmin from Nagpur, who lands in Kashi during Akbar's time. Those days, everyone wanted to be in Kashi. It was the New York and Harvard of the East," says Biswas. Bhatta, a leading figure in the Brahmin activism that was reshaping the city, wished to increase his prestige. And the best way to do it, then as now, was to build a temple. He peruses the Puranas and other texts to select a new site, carve out a new sacred geography. And he approaches the big names of Akbar's court: Man Singh and Todar Mal. And circa 1580, a new temple comes up, built out of funds from Akbar's federal court—it was younger than Connaught Place is now when Aurangzeb had it razed, angered by local zamindars liaising with the growing Maratha power, Shivaji. "Even the modern cremation ghat, Manikarnika, was Bhatta's conjuration," says Biswas. A bit of eternity was born in the 16th century.

THE UNFOLDING STRATEGY

The present, meanwhile, unfolds on a canvas bristling with a spirit of Hindu revivalism. The original ideological godheads, the RSS and the BJP, are lurking back though—part caught in a dilemma, part adopting a strategic middle ground. They would not mind the core Hindutva constituency being kept in a state of elation; at the same time, no government wants things to go out of control. There is indeed a sophisticated layering to the approach now, percepti-



RICHARD EATON

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ON THE SHARED HISTORY OF HINDUISM AND ISLAM

"It was in the British colonial interest to portray their native subjects as 'naturally' divided by religion. The notion that homogenised and self-aware Muslim and Hindu communities were 'always' in mutual conflict is refuted by evidence dating from the Turkish conquest of north India in the 12th century. Sanskrit inscriptions typically identified those from beyond the Khyber by their linguistic identity (i.e., 'Turushka') and not as Muslims, suggesting that they were not seen as posing any civilisational break with earlier Indian dynasties"

ON THE DESTRUCTION OF THE VISHWESHWARA TEMPLE

"Built by Akbar's general Raja Man Singh, the Vishweshwara temple was patronised in Aurangzeb's day by the Raja's descendants, at least one of whom was suspected of assisting Aurangzeb's arch-enemy Shivaji escape detention. In early 1669, the emperor ordered that temples in three Mughal cities be subject to demolition owing to reports that Brahmins in 'established schools' were giving deviant teachings to both Hindus and Muslims. Of these cities, Varanasi was singled out as being of special concern"

–as told to ***Sunil Menon***